RESEARCH FRAMEWORK / PARTNERS

Strategic Partner Assessment

A decision framework for researching potential collaborators, recording evidence of fit, and prioritising appropriate next questions.

01 Executive summary

A commissioned report would summarise the decision being considered, the scope examined, the most relevant evidence-backed observations, the main uncertainties, and the next decision points.

This illustrative document demonstrates a summary format only. It does not report actual market findings, verified organisations, client results, or recommendations about a real business.

* Decision question and intended audience
* Scope and evidence base reviewed
* Key observations with confidence and limitations
* Prioritised areas for further consideration

02 Illustrative research question

How can a team create a transparent shortlist of organisations that may warrant a partnership conversation?

03 Hypothetical context

Hypothetical demonstration: a consultancy is considering whether to explore complementary delivery relationships. No organisations, introductions, partnerships, or outcomes are real.

DEMONSTRATION ONLY

No actual findings, clients, or sources are presented.

04 Scope and methodology

A live engagement would state the agreed market or organisation boundaries, geographic coverage, time period, included and excluded questions, source types, and analytical approach.

Research steps should be proportionate to the decision and evidence available. This demonstration describes a possible report structure, not research performed against real organisations or sources.

* Research question and decision context
* Scope, inclusion criteria, and exclusions
* Public and client-supplied evidence distinguished
* Review period and analysis approach

05 Findings and analysis

A completed report would distinguish observed information from analyst interpretation and hypotheses. Each material finding would be connected to evidence and assessed against the agreed question.

No real findings, comparisons, scores, market sizes, or business outcomes are asserted in this illustrative sample.

* Observed evidence and its source
* Interpretation and relevance to the decision
* Counter-signals, confidence, and open questions
* No unsupported statistics or inferred private performance

06 Evidence and source notes

For a real research engagement, a source log can record the publisher, title, publication date, retrieval date, URL or document reference, geographic coverage, relevant claim, and known limitations.

This demonstration intentionally does not cite external sources or present its example material as verified evidence.

* Publisher and source title
* Publication and retrieval dates
* URL or document reference and supported claim
* Source quality, coverage, and known limitations

07 Limitations and uncertainties

A research report should explain information gaps, source coverage, recency, conflicting claims, assumptions, and areas requiring further validation.

This illustrative document cannot establish actual demand, market size, competitor performance, partner willingness, or future results.

* Evidence gaps and unverified assumptions
* Source and geographic coverage
* Areas where additional research may be appropriate
* No guarantee of commercial or operational outcomes

08 Recommendations

Recommendations in a live report should follow from documented evidence and the agreed decision criteria. Their rationale, dependencies, and uncertainties should remain visible.

No real-world recommendations or outcomes are claimed in this illustrative document.

* Prioritised recommendations tied to the research question
* Evidence rationale and uncertainty for each action
* Dependencies, owners, or timing only where agreed

09 Proposed next steps

Potential next steps may include gathering additional evidence, testing a defined hypothesis, consulting relevant specialists, or reviewing specified indicators.

A live engagement would agree responsibilities, timing, and review points with the client. This demonstration does not claim that any action has been taken or that an outcome is assured.

* Identify the most important unresolved question
* Agree what additional evidence would help answer it
* Set proportionate review points and decision criteria
* Revisit conclusions as relevant evidence changes

10 Partnership objective and guardrails

State the business objective the potential relationship could support and identify what type of relationship is being considered. Referral, distribution, delivery, data, and product partnerships have different requirements.

Document non-negotiable requirements, excluded relationship types, geographic boundaries, and any reputational, regulatory, or operational considerations that require specialist review.

* Business objective and intended value exchange
* Relationship type and candidate boundaries
* Required capabilities and constraints
* Approval, due-diligence, and escalation needs

11 Candidate identification and screening

Identify candidate organisations using documented inclusion criteria and attributable sources. Separate an initial longlist from any shortlist and state why candidates were selected for further consideration.

Screen for basic observable alignment such as service complementarity, stated customer focus, geography, and publicly described capabilities. Do not claim internal willingness or capacity from public materials.

* Documented discovery and selection approach
* Basic public profile for each candidate
* Observed complementarity and potential overlap
* Known gaps requiring direct confirmation

12 Strategic-fit criteria

Agree fit criteria with the commissioning team before comparing candidates. Criteria may include strategic relevance, complementarity, customer overlap, delivery dependencies, and evidence confidence.

If a scoring rubric is used, make the definitions, weighting, and evidence basis explicit. Scores organise discussion; they do not prove partner suitability.

* Criteria, definitions, and any agreed weighting
* Evidence references for each observation
* Risks, dependencies, and unknowns
* Rationale for prioritisation or deferral

13 Relationship hypothesis and diligence questions

Frame a potential collaboration as a hypothesis that requires confirmation by both parties. Identify questions about incentives, responsibilities, customer experience, data handling, governance, and operational readiness.

Business intelligence research cannot substitute for legal, financial, security, or compliance due diligence. Flag when a specialist review is required before proceeding.

* Possible value exchange to validate
* Roles and customer-facing responsibilities
* Data, confidentiality, and governance questions
* Specialist due diligence or approval requirements

14 Illustrative assessment format

A report can include candidate profiles, a transparent criteria matrix, evidence references, open questions, and a prioritised discussion list. This illustrative document contains no real candidates or partner recommendations.

An initial research priority indicates where further exploration may be useful; it is not an endorsement, introduction, or confirmation that a relationship can be formed.

* Candidate and evidence register
* Fit observations with unknowns made visible
* Potential discussion questions
* Recommended next diligence steps

15 Limitations and potential outputs

Public information cannot establish intent, availability, financial health, contractual suitability, or willingness to collaborate. Information can also be incomplete or become outdated.

Potential outputs include an organisation longlist, researched profiles, a fit-criteria worksheet, a source log, and next-step questions for the client's own outreach and diligence.

* No contact is made on the client's behalf unless separately agreed
* No endorsement or verified relationship is implied
* No legal or financial due-diligence opinion
* Candidate coverage follows the agreed selection scope